

Islamic Extremism and Bangsamoro Transition

Philippines, Mindanao

SIGNAL

The BARMM parliamentary election is confirmed for September 14, but the convergence of MILF fragmentation, a major earthquake, and a rising violent extremism trendline has created a compounding crisis ahead of the polls.

FRACTURE

The BFP's break from the MILF's UBJP, the Iqbal corruption crisis, and the magnitude-7.8 earthquake have together eroded the transitional authority's cohesion at the precise moment it needs to demonstrate credible governance.

The Marcos administration will use the BTA extension to increase Manila's direct influence over BARMM governance, reducing MILF autonomy in the name of election stability.

75%

PROBABILITY

TARGET: MARCH 2027

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

WHAT'S NEW

- **Mindanao earthquake (June 8):** A magnitude-7.8 earthquake struck offshore Maasim, Sarangani, killing 65+ and affecting 736,400+ people across Regions IX, XI, XII, and BARMM. This compounds the pre-existing state of calamity (oil crisis + El Niño drought) and diverts government bandwidth from election preparation to disaster response.
- **BARMM election confirmed:** COMELEC Chairman Garcia confirmed (June 23) the September 14 election will proceed – no legal basis for further postponement. Campaign period set for July 30–September 12. Gun ban effective July 16.
- **Election security concerns escalate:** PRO-BAR identified 92 towns and 42 barangays as areas of concern. Up to 7,991 police personnel tasked for election security. Regional Joint Security Control Center established at WestMinCom HQ.
- **BFP entrenches as MILF rival:** Over 1,000 MILF members (including Cotabato City Mayor Bruce Matabalao) have left UBJP for the Bangsamoro Federalist Party. BFP is one of 16 parties contesting September polls and has publicly committed to clean elections.
- **Iqbal corruption deepens:** COA found P2.2–4.9 billion in irregularities at the Ministry of Basic, Higher and Technical Education (MBHTE) during Iqbal's tenure. Macacua ordered charges filed before the Ombudsman. MILF Central Committee suspended Macacua as BIAF Chief of Staff – a retaliatory move exposing the depth of the UBJP–BFP rift.

- ****Save Bangsamoro Movement protests:**** Protests at Mendiola, Manila (June 15) appealed to Marcos to "restore the leadership" of BARMM, expressing concern over unilateral national government actions on the GPH-MILF peace agreement.
- ****ASEAN SCS Code of Conduct push:**** Philippines targets end-2026 COC completion. Monthly negotiations underway. 59th AMM scheduled July 21. Analysts remain skeptical of a binding agreement.
- ****UNOCT CT TECH+ workshop (June 4-5):**** Manila hosted a UN-INTERPOL workshop on countering terrorist use of new technologies – a signal that the Philippines' counter-terrorism framework is being upgraded with international support.

ANALYSIS

POLITICAL

The MILF's internal fragmentation has accelerated significantly since the last report. The Bangsamoro Federalist Party is no longer merely a splinter – it has become an institutionalized rival with 1,000+ defectors from UBJP, including a sitting city mayor. The Iqbal corruption scandal (P2.2–4.9 billion in COA-flagged irregularities) has provided the BFP with ammunition to argue that UBJP governance is compromised, while the MILF Central Committee's suspension of Macacua as BIAF Chief of Staff signals that the rift has penetrated the armed wing itself. With 16 parties now contesting the September polls, the electoral landscape is far more fragmented than anticipated.

The Save Bangsamoro Movement's protest at Mendiola (June 15) adds a civil-society dimension – the appeal to Marcos to "restore the leadership" of BARMM implies dissatisfaction with Manila's handling of the transition and could be leveraged by the administration to justify greater oversight. COMELEC's firm stance that the election will proceed eliminates the postponement scenario but raises the stakes: a flawed election under these conditions would be more damaging than a delayed one.

ECONOMIC

The magnitude-7.8 earthquake (June 8) has created a compounding humanitarian crisis in regions already under state of calamity from the oil crisis and El Niño drought. With 736,400+ people affected and 14 LGUs declaring states of calamity, the BARMM government is now spread across disaster response, economic stabilization, and election preparation simultaneously. The peace dividend narrative – already strained – suffers further when governance cannot deliver basic services during overlapping crises.

The broader Philippine economy faces pressure from the ongoing Hormuz energy shock, which has pushed oil above \$100/barrel. Marcos's signaling of openness to Reed Bank joint development with China reflects economic desperation but faces constitutional barriers. BARMM's fiscal autonomy remains limited, with the region heavily dependent on national government allotments that may be squeezed by competing disaster recovery and defense spending needs.

MILITARY

The MILF-Army joint anti-ISIS front (May 2026) remains a positive development, but MILF fragmentation threatens its sustainability. If Macacua's BIAF suspension leads to factional realignment within the armed wing, the operational cooperation could fray. With 43 clan-feuding incidents in the first four months of 2026 and 92 towns identified as election security concerns, the Philippine military faces a three-front challenge: South China Sea patrols, Mindanao counter-terrorism, and election security deployment for September.

The deployment of 7,991 police personnel for election security is substantial but may be insufficient for the scale of the challenge. The historical pattern of rido violence spiking during election periods, combined with the presence of ASG remnants in Sulu and IS-affiliated cells in Lanao del Sur, creates a complex threat matrix. Violent extremism incidents (40 in Jan-May 2026 vs. 29 in late 2025) are trending upward, and the earthquake's displacement of communities may create new recruitment pools for extremist groups.

TECHNOLOGICAL

The UNOCT CT TECH+ workshop in Manila (June 4-5) – a joint effort with INTERPOL and the Philippine Anti-Terrorism Council – signals that the Philippines is engaging with international partners on counter-terrorism technology capacity-building. The focus on public-private partnerships to counter terrorist use of new technologies is relevant to Mindanao, where encrypted messaging platforms continue to facilitate extremist recruitment.

The broader trend of AI-enabled radicalization (flagged by the Tacloban school shooting investigation, where NTF-ELCAC raised concerns about online radicalization pathways) adds urgency. However, the Philippine military's cyber capabilities remain limited relative to the threat, and operational outcomes from the UNOCT workshop have yet to materialize.

WATCH INDICATORS

- BFP vs. UBJP candidate slates and campaign rhetoric escalation
- Post-earthquake security incidents in BARMM and surrounding regions
- Marcos administration statements on BARMM election integrity and oversight
- MILF armed wing (BIAF) cohesion following Macacua's suspension
- ISIS-affiliated activity levels during campaign period (July 30–September 12)
- ASEAN AMM (July 21) outcomes on South China Sea Code of Conduct
- Rido violence trends during gun ban period (July 16 onward)
- International observer or mediator engagement with the election process

PROBABILITY TRIGGERS

EVENT	DIRECTION
Marcos administration announces BTA extension with new Manila-appointed oversight powers	Up
MILF factions unite against Manila's extension terms	Down
Major election-related violence disrupts September polls	Up
International mediators broker a power-sharing agreement preserving MILF autonomy	Down
Post-earthquake humanitarian crisis derails election preparation	Up
ASEAN AMM produces substantive SCS Code of Conduct progress	Down (frees Manila's bandwidth)
BIAF fragmentation leads to armed MILF faction clashes	Up
COMELEC-certified peaceful elections with MILF participation	Down

KEY SOURCES

- COMELEC confirmation of BARMM election (June 23, 2026)
- CCAA briefer on BARMM election violence risk
- Manila Bulletin: MILF Central Committee suspends Macacua as BIAF Chief
- PhilStar: BFP commits to clean elections
- Mindanao earthquake reporting (June 8)
- FULCRUM/ISEAS: SCS structural stalemate analysis
- UNOCT CT TECH+ workshop Manila (June 4-5)

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